

Prelude in Phuoc Long

The fall of Phuoc Long in January 1975 opened the final phase of the war. It showed that neither the United States nor South Vietnam had the resolve to stop a communist victory.

◀◀ BEFORE

After the withdrawal of American forces from Vietnam, scattered but persistent fighting continued in spite of an agreed ceasefire.

TESTING THE WATERS

President Richard Nixon had promised renewed military intervention in defense of South Vietnam if required. However, Congress was determined to block any such action. Facing impeachment as a result of the [Watergate scandal](#), in August 1974 Nixon resigned the presidency. Meanwhile, the North Vietnamese prepared for a future major offensive, **building up their forces** and developing their supply routes to the South.



SOLDIER OF NORTH VIETNAMESE ARMY

In October 1974, the North Vietnamese leadership held a meeting to discuss how best to proceed toward their goal of final victory in Vietnam. On the one hand, Le Duan and his colleagues believed that the resignation of Richard Nixon had sharply reduced the chances of any renewal of US military intervention. They also noted that the performance of South Vietnamese (ARVN) forces had deteriorated over the year.

On the other hand, their efforts to build up stores of heavy equipment and develop a supply system to their troops in the South were still far from complete. The members of the politburo also continued to be wary of the possible US response to a full-scale offensive, even under the presidency of Gerald Ford. The result of their deliberations was to authorize an all-out assault to capture Phuoc Long province, in the Central Highlands near the Cambodian border. If the United States failed to respond and the ARVN performed poorly, the communists would sense the way was open for them to escalate operations further in 1975.

NVA superiority

The attack on Phuoc Long, set to be launched in December 1974, was masterminded by General Tran Van Tra, who amassed a force of two infantry divisions, a tank battalion, an artillery regiment, and an antiaircraft regiment, plus support units. In contrast, remote and